Siddaramiah's gambit to take on the BJP by creating a 'Tamil type of north-south divide' didn't succeed for this reason. While other states have a history of political mobilisation around language or regional identity, Karnataka has been a conglomeration of four or five language groups, each concentrated in specific regions. The state's diversity and multilingualism mean that, relatively speaking, the fear of a north Indian hegemon does not evoke the same reaction as it does in other southern states. 'There is no regional force in Karnataka. When Indira Gandhi constituted a task force for Chikmagalur, the actor Dr Raj Kumar was asked to contest, but he refused. So, no regional force was created in Karnataka,' the journalist and academic Veeraraghav explained to me in early 2020. 'Karnataka is a combination of four–five regions with contradictions between them. JD(S) is largely a regional force of Vokkaligas but has a base only in Old Mysore, where BJP finds it difficult to win.'

While the BJP never had a presence in Tamil Nadu, it used to win about five or six assembly seats in Hyderabad and outer Hyderabad in the 1980s, at a time when it was winning only about a dozen seats in Karnataka. So why did it not grow in Andhra like it did in Karnataka? Some Karnataka BJP leaders say the difference lies in the leadership and its ability to create a rural base. 'It is because we got everything wrong there [in Andhra]. We didn't have a top leader and they didn't have the vision to grow outside the city, like we did in Karnataka. We were seen in Andhra as an urban party focused on Hyderabad and not concerned with the agrarian issues. The agrarian issues are never touched by them, but in Karnataka that was the basis of Yediyurappa's initial growth as Rayatu Bandhu,' a BJP leader explained. 'Yediyurappa appealed to farmers, SC/STs. Even today, if you ask Muslims or Christians, they find BSY the most secular leader you will find among all parties. What Amit Shah is today, what Modi is today, he was that all those years ago in Karnataka but he can't speak in Hindi. He had the moderate face of Vajpayee and this killer instinct of Shah and Modi. It was a deadly combination for us.'[109]

The BJP had similar origins in Andhra and Karnataka, but its paths in the two states diverged in the 1990s. Party leaders say they made no progress in Andhra because 'there was no primary leader'